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The Great Gatsby: Confused Love in a Lying World

“Does Gatsby truly love Daisy?” Whenever I think of *The Great Gatsby*, I cannot help questioning why Gatsby loves Daisy so persistently and so desperately. As a poor boy from North Dakota whose parents are both “shiftless and unsuccessful farm people” (p. 52), Jay Gatsby grows from the bottom of the society, which makes him “knew women early” and “became contemptuous of them” (p. 52) — before the predestined encounter with Daisy in the summer of Louisville, he has never been fascinated by any other woman. Nevertheless, why it is Daisy, the most egocentric and artificial woman in the novel, that becomes Gatsby’s lifetime obsession? Interestingly, even Gatsby himself probably does not realize the reason. However, careful readers might gain some clues from Nick Carraway’s narration. As an outsider, Nick keenly observes that Gatsby’s love for Daisy makes him confused and disordered, to some extent, he loves Daisy because “he wanted to recover something, some idea of himself perhaps, that had gone into loving Daisy” (p. 59). Perhaps in Gatsby’s mind, among this world full of lies and deceits, Daisy is a religion, a belief, just like that green light at the end of her dock, like “the orgastic future that year by year recedes before us” (p. 99). Everything Gatsby has done to pursue Daisy, the girl from the class beyond his reach, is nothing different from running faster and stretching out further to touch that ephemeral green light, is nothing different from dreaming of entering the upper society where he never gets a real footing.

Many readers might think the love between Gatsby and Daisy is like the love of Romeo and Juliet, however, the enormous gulf of social classes has overshadowed the couple since the beginning of their first unexpected encounter. In that “enchanted” summer of Louisville when Gatsby and Daisy secretly pledged their marriage, what Gatsby has is nothing more than a lieutenant uniform, but Daisy is “by far the most popular of all the young girls in Louisville” (p. 39), is “safe and proud above the hot struggles of the poor” (p. 83). As readers, we may never know what makes that eighteen-year-old young girl incurably love such a poor boy who has no ability to give any guarantee for their future life. Perhaps at that time, Daisy, as herself says, is just a “beautiful little fool” who enjoys being a confused lover. After all, playing like a “beautiful little fool” is “the best thing a girl can be in this world” (p. 9), since she still has a long future unfolding ahead of her, and she still has plenty of youth to squander.

Daisy is lucky, because of her superior family background, she has a lot of alternatives besides Gatsby. But Gatsby is not, unfortunately, he is among those poor people in Nick’s father’s motto, “that all the people in this world haven’t had the advantages that you’ve had.” (p. 1) — in order to deserve Daisy, he has no choice but to struggle and climb upwards in the society. Maybe the destiny has secretly promised Gatsby success since his childhood, just as his father says, “Jimmy was bound to get ahead. He always had some resolves like this or something.” (p. 95). After strengthening his resolve to marry Daisy, Gatsby determinedly starts his expedition for money and status, and finally becomes the mysterious party host who spends money like water, dreaming for an uncertain reunion with the girl he loves. But everything has changed, although Gatsby is not a nobody anymore, however, Daisy is no longer that “beautiful little fool”. Years of luxurious life has shaped her into a hypocritical egoist, “her artificial world was redolent of orchids and pleasant, cheerful snobbery and orchestras which set the rhythm of the year” (p. 83),

although she has long been tired of her husband's rudeness, she could not deny the fact that from the bottom of her heart, she "did love him (Tom) once" (p. 73). In fact, in Daisy's eyes, Tom is more reliable than Gatsby, so after Myrtle's death, by deceiving Gatsby, Daisy gets away with her crime at the expense of Gatsby's tragedy.

At the end of the novel, Daisy finally understands who is more important to her: Gatsby represents her life in the past, but Tom will determine her life in the future. But until his death, Gatsby is still confused by his love for Daisy. He could not believe that Daisy, the girl who consists of all his past, present, and future, lies to him — Gatsby still thinks he is the only person that Daisy has ever loved, and "don't think she ever loved him (Tom)" (p. 83). For Gatsby, Daisy is the meaning of his lifelong enterprise, without this confused love, how could he convince himself to taking the risk of becoming a bootlegger, how could he not question himself "What was the use of doing great things if I could have a better time telling her what I was going to do?" (p. 83). Perhaps if God gives Gatsby the opportunity to survive Wilson's bullet, he might sit by the green light and wait for the arrival of his lover, but probably, the only person that also awaits Gatsby is some final guest from somewhere at the end of the earth, who endures the hardship of a long journey just to join his grand party that has long been over.

Reference

- [1] Fitzgerald, F. Scott. *The Great Gatsby*. Web. <https://www.wsfcs.k12.nc.us/cms/lib/NC01001395/Centricity/Domain/7935/Gatsby_PDF_FullText.pdf>. Accessed 6 March 2020.